The Woman Behind India's Publishing Legacy and Its Multi-Sector Expansion

As the Managing Director of MBD Group, Monica Malhotra Kandhari balances legacy with expansion, steering the organisation across printing, publishing, edtech, hospitality and global ventures.


Monica Malhotra Kandhari, Managing Director, MBD Group

A LEGACY REIMAGINED

Founded in 1956 as a modest bookshop in Jalandhar by Shri Ashok Kumar Malhotra, MBD Group grew into one of India's leading education companies, built on a steadfast commitment to accessible and affordable learning. Carrying this legacy forward, second-generation entrepreneur Monica Malhotra Kandhari entered the business at a young age and later stepped into the role of Managing Director, guiding the organisation through a rapidly evolving educational landscape.

From hands-on experience on the shop floor to authoring award-winning titles such as Children's Picture Dictionary and Begin with A, her journey reflects creativity, discipline, and deep industry insight. Today, she oversees a portfolio of over 8,000 titles and a growing international presence — with MBD recognised as the only Indian-origin publisher featured in South Africa's National Catalogue, a publishing office in Cape Town, and accredited titles in Sri Lanka — reinforcing the Group's global credibility.

INDUSTRY LEADERSHIP ROLES

Beyond the organisation, she contributes actively to the industry's larger framework, serving as a key member of CII (Northern Regional Council), Chair of the FICCI Publishing Committee and an Executive Committee Member of the Federation of Indian Publishers (FIP). She is also a member of the Educational Publishers Forum, International Publishers Association (IPA), and a member of the Senate of Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar.

THE EDTECH EVOLUTION: AASOKA AND BEYOND

Recognising the shift toward digital learning, she led MBD's expansion into educational technology with the launch of AASOKA in 2021. Designed as a blended learning ecosystem integrating print and digital resources, it aligns with NEP 2020 and NCF and supports CBSE, ICSE, and State Boards. AI-enabled tools enhance classroom delivery, improve teacher efficiency, and enable personalised learning experiences.

Since its launch, AASOKA has partnered with over 4,000 schools, supporting 9.5 lakh students and training more than 80,000 teachers. Its footprint extends beyond India into South Africa, the Middle East, and other international markets, reflecting growing global adoption. Under her leadership, AASOKA was ranked No. 1 in TIME World's Top EdTech Rising Stars of 2025.

EXPANDING THE ENTERPRISE

Hospitality has become a defining pillar of the MBD Group's diversification, with Monica Malhotra Kandhari heading the design and construction of its hospitality projects. Her sister, Sonica Malhotra Kandhari, Joint Managing Director, MBD Group, leads the hospitality and realty portfolio, driving its continued expansion. Together, they oversee commercial and residential developments, guiding the vision, execution, and long-term growth of landmark projects internationally. From established hospitality destinations such as Radisson Blu MBD Hotel Noida to prominent lifestyle and retail destinations like MBD Neopolis Mall in Jalandhar, the Group reflects a strong presence across integrated real estate and hospitality ventures. Further strengthening its hospitality leadership, the MBD Group has secured a prestigious Master Franchise Agreement for India with Radisson Hotel Group, including development rights for Radisson Collection MBD Hotels and Radisson RED MBD Hotels across the country. In Udaipur, Pichola Villas at Lake Pichola adds a boutique hospitality dimension rooted in cultural heritage. The Group's catering arm, Saffron & Gold, further complements its lifestyle portfolio through curated private and corporate hospitality experiences.

A LEADERSHIP OF CONTINUITY

Monica Malhotra Kandhari has received wide recognition for her contributions to education and enterprise. She was featured in Forbes India as an Iconic Woman Leader and honoured as Woman Entrepreneur in Education at the ET Education Excellence Awards 2025, among others. She is also a sought-after speaker at global forums, reflecting her continued influence and leadership.